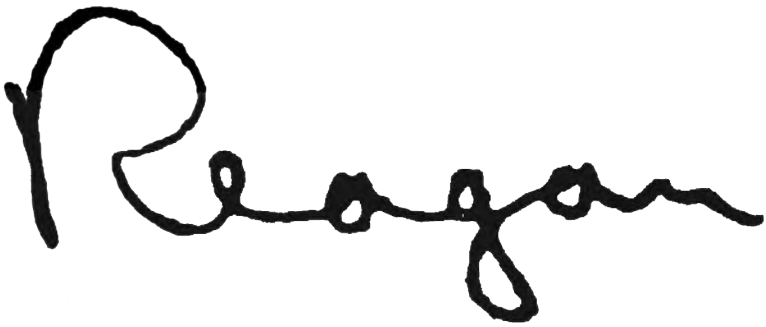


A LIFE IN LETTERS



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FREE PRESS

NEW YORK • LONDON • TORONTO • SYDNEY • SINGAPORE

In this letter to his favorite fan Reagan describes what his son, Ron—now 21 years old—is doing. Mel Thomson was governor of New Hampshire. William "Bill" Loeb was the publisher of the Manchester Union Leader. *The author of the book,* Here's the Rest of Him, *was Kent Steffgen.*

Mr. and Mrs. Elwood H. Wagner
Philadelphia, Pennsylvania
June 5, 1979[30]

Dear Lorraine and Wag:

You've had quite a time with our friends at *Spotlight.* It makes you wonder what kind of an editor he is to write the insulting, sarcastic letter that he wrote. My own informants in Washington tell me that the man running *Spotlight* can literally be described as a Nazi.*

You asked about my affirming support for Red China. I think what he must be referring to is a passage in a speech in which I said that probably all of us, maybe I should have said most, approve of the bettering of relations with mainland China. That was not the issue. The issue was the dumping of a long time friend and ally, the Republic of China on Taiwan, and I then added that we could have had everything we now have with Red China without betraying Taiwan.

As for Mel Thomson, I don't know just what the situation is there. Mel, last time I spoke to him, was as friendly as he has always been. His close friend, Bill Loeb, the publisher of the paper there, is a little worried that Mel somehow has gone off the track, not with regard to me, but with the idea that possibly it is time for a third party or something of that sort.

I think that *Spotlight* is basing most of its articles on that book called, *Here's the Rest of Him,* but I also believe the same author has now come out with a new book that is something of a rehash of the first.

I will look into the matter of the radio scripts. We've had some changes of personnel at the office. That might have accounted for it. We aren't doing reruns—I am continuing to come up with new ones every week.

Regarding the date for the declaration, we have no such date—we just know it's going to come sometime this fall.

And the ranch name is *Rancho del Cielo,* which means ranch in the sky. It was an old Spanish land grant—it's up at about a 2,400 foot level so we thought that name was kind of appropriate.

It's nice to hear about Sandy and Scott, give them my best. I am very familiar with the Ambassador East. It used to be the dining spot when you would come

* Willis A. Carto, who was born in 1926, founded and controlled Liberty Lobby, the organization that published *Spotlight.*

into Chicago by train from the west and leave that night for New York on the Century.

Patti is doing some singing and song writing and a little TV work. She has had bit parts on a couple of *Love Boat* shows, and Ron has a scholarship in New York. He is all wrapped up in dancing. The ballet kind, believe it or not. It all started a few years ago when he was playing football and basketball and that idea hit the athletic world that ballet was a great exercise for athletes. Even the pros were getting into it. It caught his fancy, and I hasten to assure you he is an athlete and all man, and he's working like the devil at this, knowing that possibly he waited and started too late in life, but he wants to give it a try.

Thanks again for taking on *Spotlight,* but don't look forward to converting them. I think they are beyond help.

All the best,

Ron

Edward Hickey had been Reagan's security chief in Sacramento and worked for him after he left the governorship and in the White House.[24]

Mr. Edward V. Hickey
Oxon Hill, Maryland
After the 1976 convention[25]

Dear Ed:

Nancy and I are both more grateful than we can say for a truly heartwarming letter. Thank you.

We are at peace with ourselves and believe the Lord must have something else in mind for us to do. I'm starting the radio programs right away and soon will be back in the papers with a column and, of course, there is always the mashed potato circuit. I'll be doing my best to see that the good Dr.* doesn't give away the Canal, Taiwan, or the rest of our military. It would have been easier the other way, but now we'll try by remote control.

Nancy sends her love and please give our best to Barbara and the boys. We both hope we'll see you soon.

Sincerely,
Ron

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* Dr. Henry Kissinger, Ford's (and formerly Nixon's) secretary of state.

Allen Drury wrote novels about Washington politics. Two of his books, Mark Coffin, U.S.S.: A Novel of Capitol Hill *and* The Hill of Summer: A Novel of the Soviet Conquest, *were published in 1981.*

Mr. Allen Drury
Tiburon, California
July 15, 1981[43]

Dear Allen:

I have waited to answer your good letter of June 1 until I could complete reading your book.

First of all, let me thank you for that and for the inscription. It will go on the shelf in the White House library, but it took me a while to read it because most of

my own personal reading is limited to that last brief period before the lights go out after I've done all the "homework" I bring home with me. Sometimes I've had to force myself to turn out the light. I enjoyed that book so much. You know, when I read all the others, I was, of course, an outsider in Washington. It was quite something to read this one here in the White House where I have the problems faced by the principal in your book. Nancy is now going to get a chance to read it, but I told her I had to read it first because I was learning how to be president. I very much feel you have come close to the truth as to what perhaps my problems will be.

Now, however, let me comment on the other reading; your letter, which I have just finished reading again. As you know, I have twice been a visitor to Taiwan, met with President Chiang and, before him, his father the Generalissimo. Some of the names you mentioned are familiar to me. I was, of course, greatly disturbed by the Carter move. I think it was unnecessary and that he could have obtained an improved relationship with the PRC [People's Republic of China] without betraying our longtime friend and ally. I am going to continue a policy of trying to improve relations with the PRC but in no way at the expense of Taiwan. I have taken steps not to downgrade but to increase the relationship between our two countries in that we have communication at high levels with the Taiwan commission, once the Embassy, here. The information you have given me in your letter is going to be most helpful to me, particularly with those diplomat types whose first instinct is to look for a way out.

Nancy sends her very best regards and, again, I thank you for your book and for your letter.

Sincerely,
Ron

The People's Republic of China and Taiwan

Ronald Reagan was deeply interested in and involved with Sino-American relations for many years. He first visited Taiwan in October 1971. Three years after he stepped down as governor, Reagan again traveled to Taiwan and declared his opposition to the Carter administration's efforts to normalize relations with the People's Republic of China. On December 15, 1978, President Jimmy Carter announced that United States relations with the PRC would be normalized on January 1, 1979, and the United States would notify Taiwan of its intention to withdraw from the Mutual Defense Treaty of 1954. In a January 15, 1979, letter to a couple in Taipei, Reagan revealed that he would use his nationally syndicated radio program to influence the U.S. Congress to oppose President Carter's policies. On February 10, Reagan urged conservatives to support Senator Barry Goldwater's (R-Arizona) court challenge to President Carter's termination of the U.S.–Taiwan defense pact.[19]

While the Reagan administration supported Taiwan, U.S.–PRC ties deepened during the 1980s. An August 17, 1982, joint communiqué with the PRC stated that the United States would not "carry out a long-term policy of arms sales to Taiwan." In late April 1984, President Reagan traveled to the PRC, making his first trip to a Communist country. When asked about Taiwan during an interview with Chinese television representatives on April 28, he said: "We don't believe that it would be right to cast aside longtime old friends in order to make new friends. But we will do anything we can to encourage the peaceful solution of this problem by the peoples of China."

The letters in this section reflect two decades of Ronald Reagan's thinking about and involvement with Sino-American relations.

Dr. Yung Wei
Circa late 1960s or 1970s[20]

Dear Dr. Wei:

Thank you very much for your letter and for sending me your article on Taiwan. I haven't read it as yet but have it on my bed stand and intend doing so.

I am very concerned about our foreign policy and the seeming obsession with détente. I feel we must continue our alliance with the Republic of China on Taiwan and never give anyone the impression that we are weakening in our pledge to defend it.

Thank you again and best wishes in your new work at the Institute of International Relations. I would enjoy hearing from you.

Sincerely,
Ronald Reagan

This letter was written shortly after Reagan returned from a trip in 1971 to Taiwan and other Asian countries on behalf of the Nixon administration. He was sent to

reassure allies of U.S. commitment to them even though an opening to the PRC would be taking place.

Mrs. Frances Cooke
La Canada, California
Circa December 1971[21]

Dear Mrs. Cooke:

I appreciate your telling me your position and thus giving me the chance to reply.

I have no disagreement whatsoever with the statements relative to the evil of communism contained in the articles by Congressman Schmitz and Senator Richardson.* I am aware of the Communists' determination to communize the world, and agree they have not retreated one inch from that position. But may I suggest there is in each article an assumption that is not verified? Both men, and I know them well and like them very much, have assumed that the president no longer shares this belief in and understanding of the danger of communism.

There is no basis for believing this and therefore assuming that Taiwan is doomed or that we will abandon old friends such as President Chiang Kai-shek.† As a matter of fact President Nixon has told me directly that if the Red Chinese should go adventuring and attempt the takeover of Taiwan they would have to fight the United States.

Now may I sketch in something of the situation as inherited by the president. We no longer have the nuclear superiority we had under Kennedy and which was frittered away by Kennedy and Johnson. We are close to the point at which an ultimatum by Russia would see us with no choice but surrender or die. Right now China and Russia are at odds with each other. There are 140 Russian divisions on the Chinese border. When two of our enemies are angry at each other—it is hardly to our advantage to buddy up to the stronger of the two.

At the moment President Nixon is fighting desperately to improve our defense posture in the face of tremendous congressional opposition. He won the ABM issue by one vote (Vice President Agnew's) in the Senate.‡

The Democratic position is in favor of even more disarmament. I'm sure that a

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* John George Schmitz (R-California) and Hubert Leon Richardson, a Republican state senator in California.

† Chiang Kai-shek, also known as Chiang Chung-cheng, was the Chinese Nationalist leader. He and the Nationalist regime were driven off the mainland in 1949 and established their government on Taiwan. Chiang died in 1975.

‡ On August 6, 1969, Vice President Spiro T. Agnew cast the tie-breaking vote in the United States Senate on behalf of the development of the Safeguard anti-ballistic missile system. "Even though the margin of victory was razor thin," President Richard Nixon later wrote, "the vote established that America was still prepared to maintain its military strength." Richard Nixon, *The Memoirs of Richard Nixon* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 1990), p. 418. In this letter, Reagan paints a much gloomier picture about America's military strength and diplomatic resolve during those years.

new Democrat president would visit Peking and I'm sure he would go to negotiate the liquidation of Taiwan.

Thanks again for letting me comment and please accept my belated "Thanksgiving wishes."

Sincerely,
Ronald Reagan

In a letter to a former assistant attorney general, Reagan writes that he supports the legal challenge to the termination of the 1954 defense agreement with Taiwan introduced by Senator Barry Goldwater and other legislators on December 22, 1978. On December 13, 1979, the Supreme Court ruled that President Carter's action could stand.

Mr. Norman Littell
Circa late 1979[22]

Dear Norman:

Thank you very much for your good letter and sound advice and suggestions.

I agree with you regarding the right of the president to revoke a treaty as he did with Taiwan. Since you wrote, of course, the judge has been overruled, but I understand that the group sponsoring this move is appealing to the Supreme Court. I hope they will use some good judgment. I share your admiration for Taiwan. I have been there twice—once to meet with Chiang Kai-shek as the representative of then President Nixon. The second time, after I was out of the governor's office, I met with his son, now the president of the Republic of China. More should have been made of the fact that the Communist People's Republic on the mainland started at virtually the same time the Republic of China started on Taiwan. Taiwan was a desolate waste due to the bombing by our B-29's. Comparing the two countries and what they have done is probably the greatest sermon in behalf of free enterprise anyone could ask for. I didn't know the part you had played in that, but from the information that you sent, I see that you helped draft the blueprint that made this success possible. You must be very proud.

You were very kind to send the invitation regarding the Sulgrave Club, but I'm afraid we're quite a considerable group wherever we go. Secret Service has been assigned to us so even a trip to the corner drugstore is a four-car caravan.

I was interested in your comment about Kennedy and what he is doing. Looking at that and looking also at the manner in which the president is using the power of the incumbency and tax dollars to further his own effort makes us realize our opponents are still of the same stripe they've always been. Isn't it strange how much they can get away with that we couldn't.

Again, thanks.

Best regards,
Ron

In the next two letters, one to Sam Yorty, the mayor of Los Angeles in the 1960s, and the other to an old friend, presidential candidate Ronald Reagan corrects press reports of how he would like to see U.S. representation in the PRC and Taiwan. In his reply to the mayor, he also informs Yorty that Taiwanese leaders are quietly keeping in touch with him.

Mayor Sam Yorty
August 18, 1980[23]

Dear Sam:

Thanks very much for your letter. I appreciated getting the word about the foreign minister. Through a roundabout way, our friends on Taiwan are keeping in touch with me, and they have expressed their confidence in me and my friendship for them and don't want me to make China an issue because, as they put it, they look forward to my being president.

I have always felt that, while the press called my statement one of advocating diplomatic recognition, that would be impossible since both Chinas insist that they are the real China. No, what I had in mind was, if I'm in a position to do so, making the private foundation liaison office on Taiwan an official one as our liaison office in Peking was official until recognition came, and we made it an embassy. Right now, it is my understanding that our people on Taiwan must meet with government officials of that country in cafés or clubs. They cannot go to a public office. And the same is true in Washington, where their people must meet our government officials in the same way and cannot actually visit them in their offices. I think you have put a word on it which I won't use until I get there. But the word is de facto.

Best regards,
Ron

Mr. Earl B. Dunckel
Washington, D.C.
September 2, 1980[24]

Dear Earl:

It was good to hear from you and to get your two letters packaged into one. I only had one question from the press about the Polish strike and I simply stated that I didn't believe it was our place to intervene in a purely domestic affair and that I hope the Soviet Union felt likewise.*

I was pleased to get the tip about Pakistan. I'm passing that on to our people to

* On August 13, 1980, Polish workers seized the Lenin shipyard at Gdansk. They demanded the right to form an independent union and for Lech Walesa to return to the union ranks. He had been dismissed in 1976 after a strikers' riot.

see if they can learn anything about it. They have some pretty good information sources.

I agree with you that my position on Taiwan is one that would be popular with the people. I have to believe this whole fuss was deliberately orchestrated by the administration. My last mention of Taiwan and improving our relations with them to offset Carter's betrayal of them, was in answer to a question by a Chinese back in May in Ohio. No fuss was raised then. There were a couple of columns that tried to portray me as wanting a two-China policy or diplomatic relations, when all I meant was to have the liaison office operate in Taiwan the way it operated in Peking before we had an embassy there. But suddenly, as the campaign gets under way, the whole China press comes out with a great furor. Well, my position is I'm not backing away one inch from where I stand on that because I don't think the mainland Chinese have any intention of giving up their relationship with us. Right now their concern is the Soviets. But I agree with you. We cannot go too far in trusting them. They don't like us any better than the Russians do.

I too have been annoyed by these unidentified staff members who are supposedly saying things and I honestly have to believe there aren't any—that this is just another one of those press tricks of wanting to say something so they attribute it to an unknown source.

It's funny you should mention about trying to pick out in advance what the press will attack and taking care of it in advance. We ourselves have decided now that we should go through every speech and try to pick out what the not-too-friendly press is going to use out of this as their lead line. At the same time, however, I am not going to be defensive and, even more important, I'll be damned if I'm going to let them press me into being cautious. I've been making speeches too long to change now.

Nancy sends her best and we both hope we see you soon.

Sincerely,
Ronald Reagan

During the first year of his presidency, Reagan writes that he is maintaining contact with Taiwan and that the Taiwanese understand the nature of U.S.–PRC relations.

Mr. John F. McIntyre Jr.
West Chester, Pennsylvania
July 9, 1981[25]

Dear Mr. McIntyre:

I'm glad you wrote as you did and have allowed me the opportunity to speak to your concern.

Please have no fear; my attitude with regard to Taiwan has not changed, and they are aware of this. I keep in contact, and they know what we must do with regard to the People's Republic, but they know also that we are going to maintain the

relationship that we have had in the past and that I have supported and endorsed during the campaign. I have personally visited Taiwan on two occasions and met with the President and other high government officials there and, as I said before, we do maintain a contact. Taiwan is a longtime friend and ally, and I will not be a party to tossing her overboard.

Again, thanks for giving me the opportunity to comment. Best regards.

Sincerely,
Ronald Reagan

A former Republican congressman from Minnesota wrote President Reagan to express his support for Taiwan, and attached letters from each of the five former U.S. ambassadors to Taiwan. The ambassadors supported selling weapons to Taiwan and the Taiwan Relations Act of 1979, which asserted that the United States would "provide Taiwan with arms of a defensive character, and . . . resist any resort to force or other forms of coercion that would jeopardize the security . . . of the people of Taiwan."

The Honorable Walter H. Judd
Washington, D.C.
May 18, 1982[26]

Dear Walter:

Thank you very much for your letter and for sending me the messages from the retired ambassadors. I'm happy to hear that you are on the mend.

I hope you know that regardless of the press stories, I have not and will not change my position on our longtime friend Taiwan. It is true there are those in certain circles who think we must trade one China for another but I don't subscribe to that. I'll be tactful and try to improve and maintain the relations with the People's Republic of China started by R[ichard] N[ixon] but there will be no lessening of our relationship with our friends on Taiwan.

I'm dropping a line to each of the ambassadors to that effect. Take care of yourself and again thanks.

Sincerely,
Ron

Reagan writes to a friend who recently had visited Taiwan.

Mr. John Morley
Laguna Hills, California
December 22, 1982[27]

Dear John:

Just received your good letter and the report on your trip. I'm happy to know that President Chiang Ching-kuo has confidence in my friendship for him and for

Taiwan and that he feels friendship for me as well. Please thank him for his message to me.

I remember with great pleasure our meeting and before that being guests in his father's home in 1972.* Please assure President Chiang that my feeling for the Republic of China remains unchanged and while we will continue to seek accord with the People's Republic of China it will not be at the expense of our friends on Taiwan.

I'd appreciate it also if you would deliver the attached photo to him on your next visit.

Sincerely,
Ron

President Reagan defends his April 1984 trip to the People's Republic of China, declares his commitment to allies around the world, and mentions his November 1983 trip to South Korea.

Mr. Joseph Becallo
West Monroe, New York
May 30, 1984[28]

Dear Mr. Becallo:

I appreciate your writing and giving me a chance to straighten out what appear to be some misconceptions. Our policies are not designed to import, "slave labor goods," as you suggest in competition with our own workers.

Trade is a two-way street. We are an exporting nation and when we develop trade relations with other countries we create jobs here. Right now our trade is out of balance largely because our dollar is so strong in comparison to foreign money that too many of them can't afford to buy from us.

Mainly however I'd like to reply to your objections about the China trip. The leaders of China today it is true are practicing socialism but they are not the leaders who carried on the killings and persecution of their people. There has been a significant change with the death of those earlier dictators. China is embarked on economic changes that in many ways are beginning to look like our own free enterprise. They have a long way to go but we can help them get there sooner.

We can do this without slighting any of our friends like Taiwan, South Korea, South Africa and Israel. We will not forsake Taiwan. I recently visited South Korea and they are becoming one of our foremost trading partners. We are working closely with South Africa to bring about independence for Namibia and elimination of the Cuban troops in Angola. Israel presently receives more help from us than any other nation in the world.

Best regards,
Ronald Reagan

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* Reagan was actually in Taiwan in October 1971.

Eight years before he would implore General Secretary Mikhail Gorbachev to "tear down this wall," Ronald Reagan was writing that the West should have torn it down and prevented its completion.

Mr. Arthur A. Kimball
Circa 1979–1980[35]

Dear Mr. Kimball:

Thank you very much for your letter, and I assure you I am heartily in accord with all that you had to say. I not only was a visitor in behalf of President Nixon in Taiwan, but, after leaving the governor's office, I visited again and had a fine meeting with the new president there and, of course, am acquainted with all of those you met with and mentioned in your letter.*

I agree with you about the lost opportunity in Berlin when we could have knocked down and prevented the completion of the wall with no hostilities following. I agree, also, there was no need to betray Taiwan in order to improve our relations with mainland China. We could have had the latter without doing the former. Let me assure you that if I do succeed in winning the presidency, I will make it very plain from the first that my goal is to restore relations with Taiwan. I have the greatest admiration for what has been accomplished there in that brave country and the warmest regard for the people of Taiwan.

Thanks again for your letter and best regards,
Ronald Reagan

* Ronald and Nancy Reagan traveled to West Germany in the fall of 1978. They were accompanied by Richard V. Allen and his wife, Pat, and Peter Hannaford and his wife, Irene. See Peter Hannaford, *The Reagans: A Political Portrait* (New York: Coward-McCann, 1983), pp. 189–90.

By the middle of 1982 the economy was still in bad shape and Reagan was having nearly as much trouble with the conservative media as he was with liberals. In this letter he replies to Nackey Loeb, who had succeeded her husband as publisher of the Union Leader. *She had sent Reagan a column by Jeffrey Hart, a professor of English at Dartmouth College. Hart had worked for Reagan during his brief presidential campaign in 1968.*

Mrs. William Loeb
Manchester, New Hampshire
June 28, 1982[19]

Dear Nackey:

How good it was to hear from you even if you did give me a polite spanking. From you I'll take it and like it.

Nackey, my old friend Jeffrey Hart based his column on some misinformation plus the image that is being created of me as being packaged and delivered by staff and aides who won't let me think for myself. First let me clear up the "misinformation." Solzhenitsyn was definitely invited to the luncheon but didn't want to be a part of the group we'd invited. For what reason I don't know. As for the "off the record" ruling on my remarks our guests had asked that our discussion be off the record—no press coverage.

Now back to the image making, that seems to be not only a theme of the liberal pundits but of the so-called "new conservatives" including some of my old friends from *Human Events* etc. It just isn't true. I'm not turning my back on Taiwan and other than a few state department types no one is trying to push me that way. Maybe my speech at the U.N. will also indicate I'm not soft on Russia. And none of our gang tried to talk me into giving up our tax cuts even though for a time half the columnists were saying they were on a near daily basis.

Maybe a few events in the last couple of days will further substantiate my claim that I'm being me. I just hope being me can accomplish all that needs to be done.

I tried a meeting with some of those conservatives I mentioned, John Lofton, Stan Evans, Alan Ryskind et al. and gave them chapter and verse on what the actual record is but it didn't do much good.

Again—it was <u>good</u> hearing from you and I thank you for sending Jeffrey's column. I hadn't seen it.

Best regards,
Ron

William Freeman wrote to complain about irresponsible government spending. He described himself as a working man.

Mr. William J. Freeman
Norfolk, Virginia
April 5, 1982[30]

Dear Mr. Freeman:

Thank you for your letter of February 10. I'm sorry to be so late in answering. You were kind to write as you did and I'm grateful.

You are correct in your description of what happens in Washington when you try to shut off the government money machine. It's a little like getting between the hog and the bucket.

Let me reassure you however about our friends on Taiwan. We will not desert them and have taken steps to rectify some of what was done in 1979.

Again thanks and best regards.

Sincerely,
Ronald Reagan